



From Novice to Digital Expert: Insights of the Learning Journeys of Fashion Design Professionals in Sri Lanka

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Background & Research Context

- Digital transformation is reshaping the global apparel and fashion industry.
- Fashion designers increasingly require digital competencies beyond traditional creative skills.
- Developing countries, including Sri Lanka, face challenges aligning fashion education with industry expectations.
- Limited understanding exists regarding how professionals actually develop digital capabilities

Digital transformation → Fashion industry → Education gap

- Amorim et al. (2025)
- Baytar (2018)
- Conlon & Gallery (2024)
- Lee (2022)
- Papahristou & Tatsi (2024)

Research Problem & Gap

Existing studies mainly focus on:

- Digital tools in fashion education
- Curriculum integration
- Technology adoption

Limited empirical evidence on:

- How fashion professionals develop digital competencies
- What educational experiences shaped their digital journeys
- How industry practice influences competency development

Research gap statement:

"Understanding professional digital learning journeys is essential for developing context-responsive strategies for fashion education."

- Amorim et al. (2025)
- Conlon & Gallery (2024)
- Papahristou & Tatsi (2024)

Research Aim & Objectives

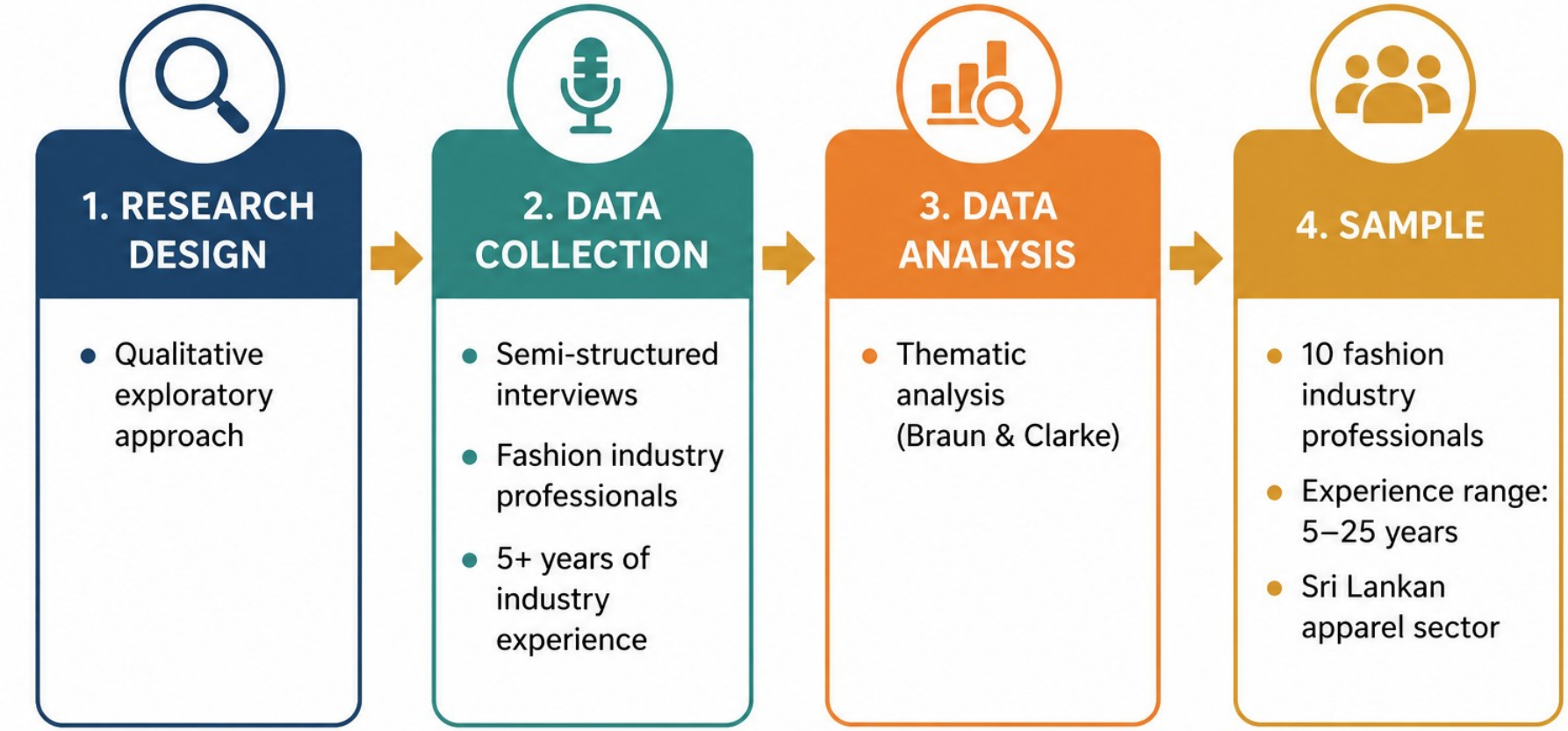
Aim:

To explore how fashion design professionals in Sri Lanka develop digital competencies and identify factors influencing their digital preparedness.

Objectives:

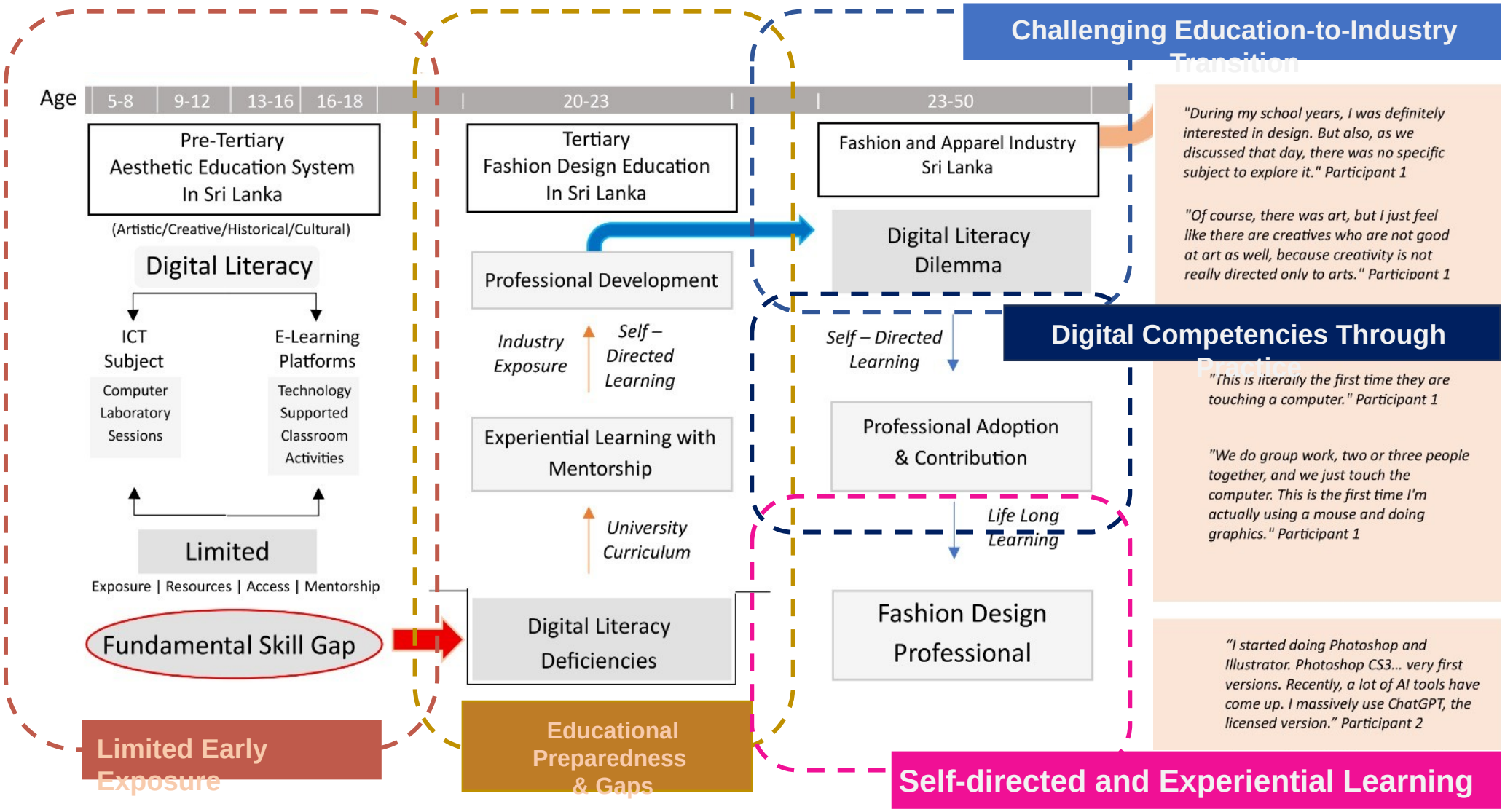
- Explore professionals' digital competency development journeys.
- Identify educational and professional experiences shaping digital capabilities.
- Understand industry expectations regarding digital competencies.
- Provide recommendations for strengthening fashion education.

Research Methodology

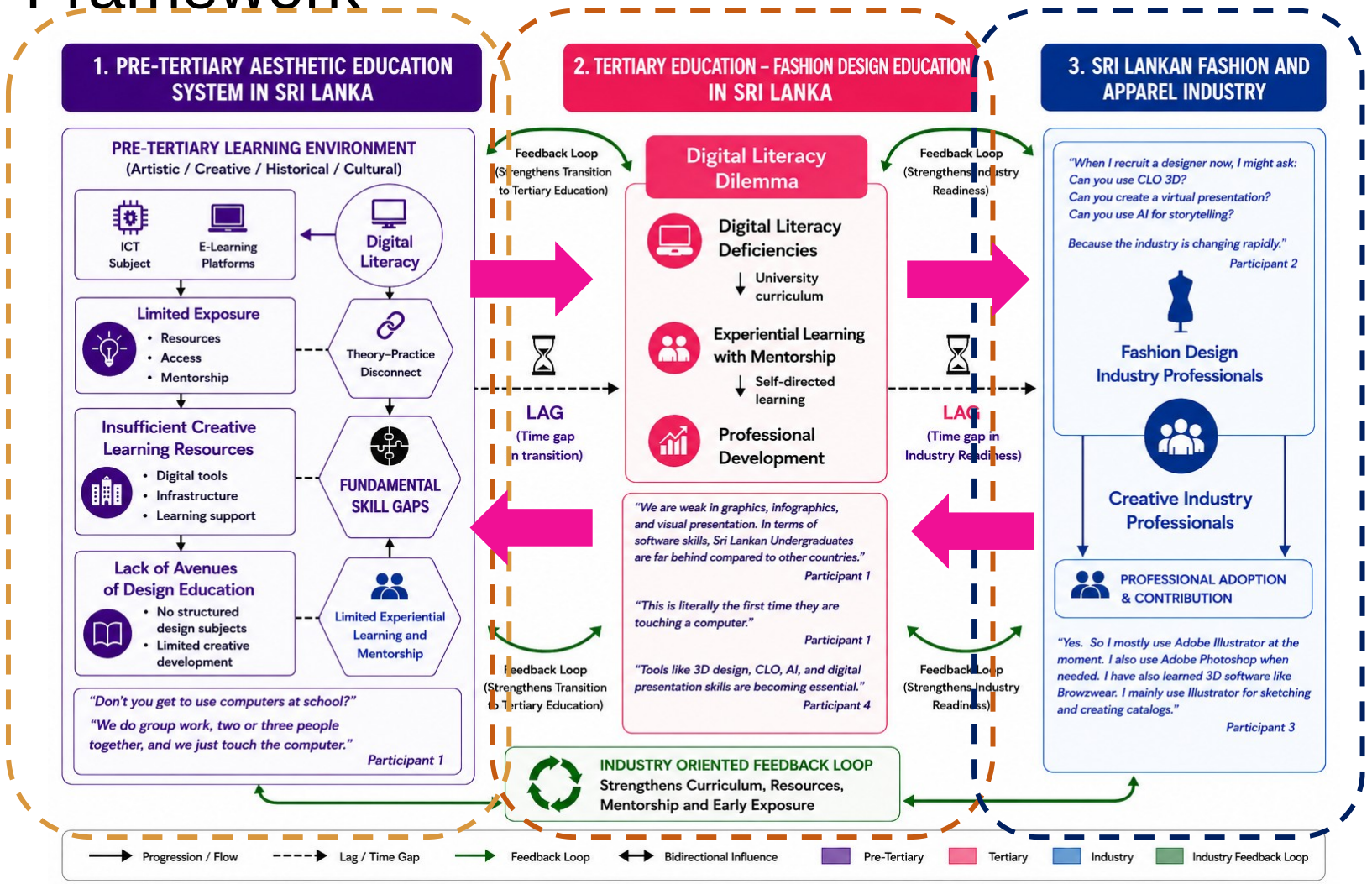


- Braun & Clarke (2022)
- Creswell & Poth (2018)

Professional Digital Competency Development Journey



Industry-Oriented Digital Competency Development Framework



I-ODCD Framework

Key Contributions

- ✓ Digital competency develops across three interconnected stages.
- ✓ Industry experience strengthens digital capability.
- ✓ Continuous self-directed learning bridges educational gaps.
- ✓ Industry feedback informs curriculum improvement.
- ✓ Collaboration between education and industry supports lifelong digital competency development.

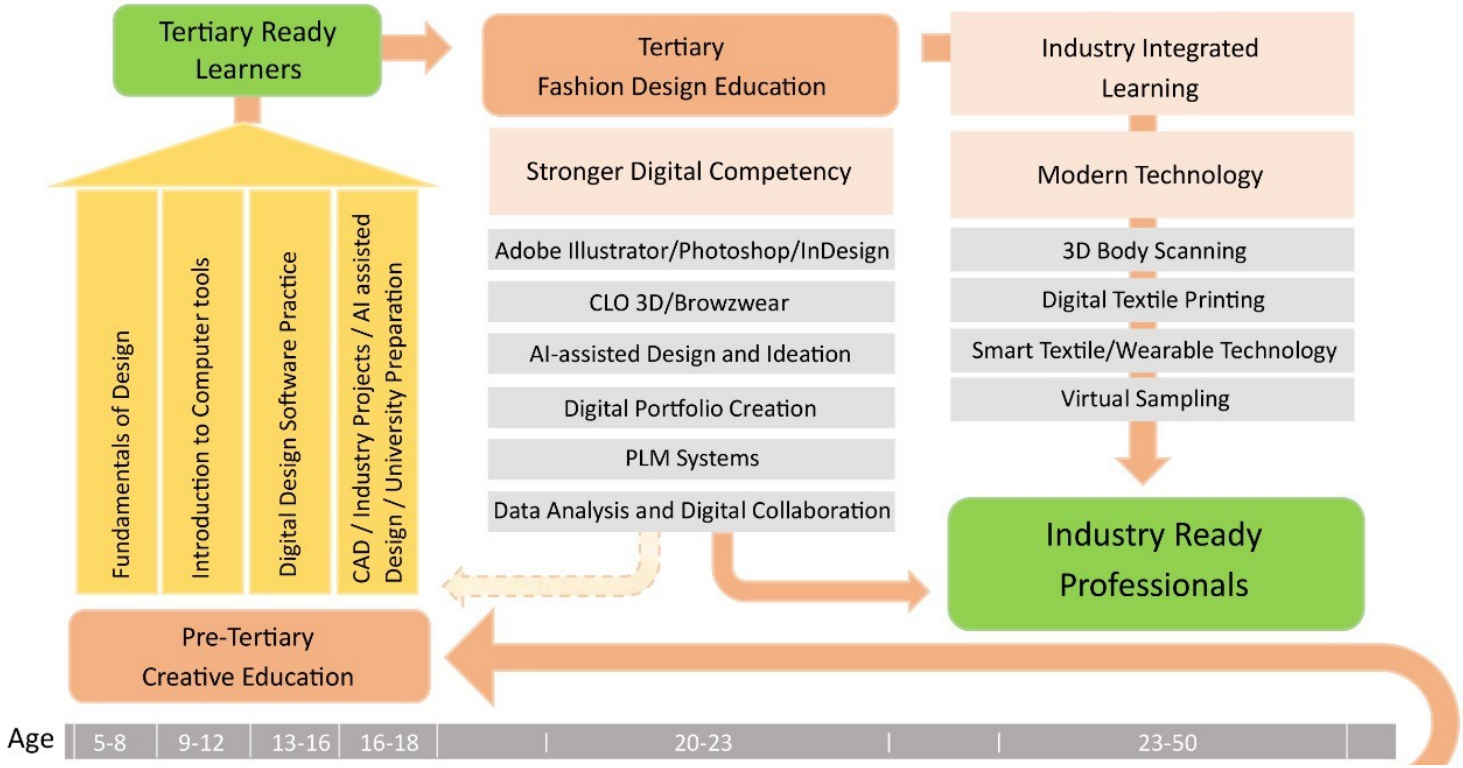
Implications & Recommendations

For Fashion Education:

- Introduce digital literacy earlier.
- Integrate industry-relevant tools.
- Strengthen academia–industry collaboration.

For Industry:

- Support graduate transition through mentoring.
- Provide continuous learning opportunities.



For Future Research:

- Validate framework across wider contexts.

Conclusion

- Digital competency development is a continuous learning journey.
- Professional practice plays a major role in building digital capabilities.
- Fashion education must evolve through stronger industry alignment.

Thank you